

Subversive Methodologies: Dadaist Approaches to Generative AI

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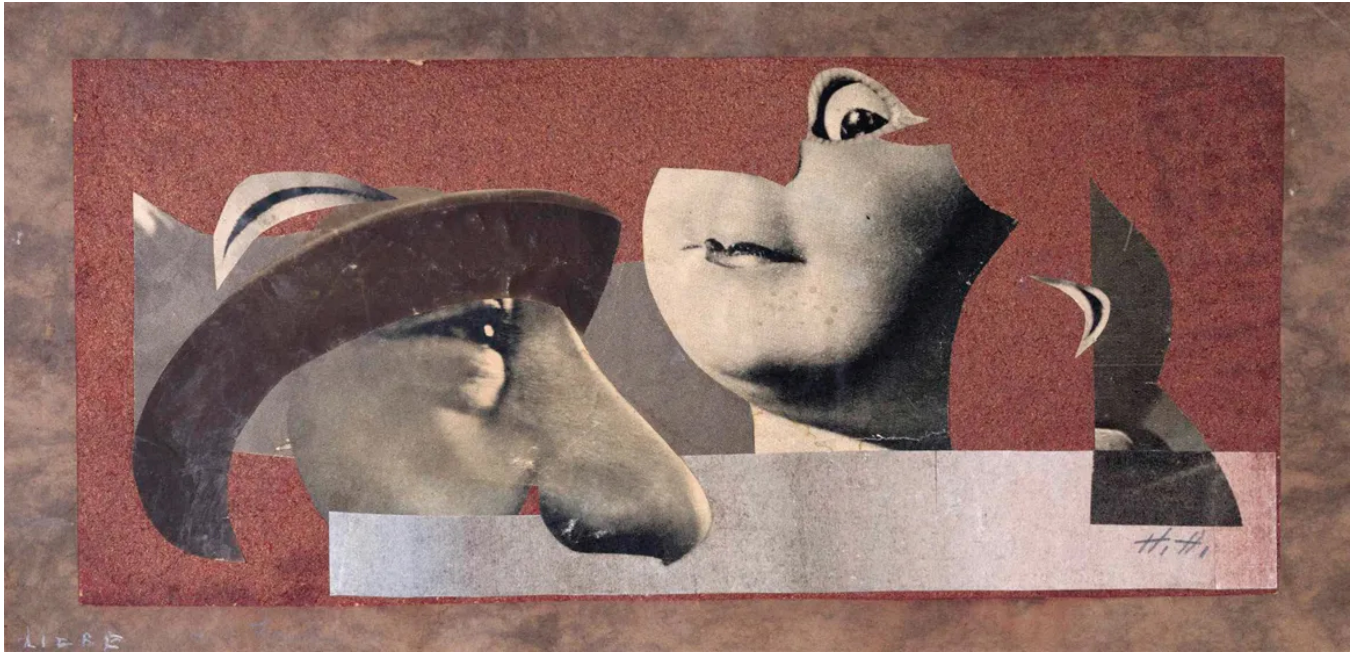


Figure 1: Hannah Höch, *Love*, ca. 1926. Collage, 13 x 27cm. © VG Bild-Kunst/Copyright Agency 2025

Abstract

Advances in generative art offer distinctive creative possibilities while also raising questions about control, power, and agency. This paper examines the parallels between Dadaist photomontage — techniques that subverted readymade images through decontextualisation and aesthetic exploration — and recent generative AI art practices. While the Dadaists harnessed appropriation to disrupt dominant narratives and express dissent, generative AI's algorithmic opacity complicates artists' agency and muddles contextual meanings. By analysing Dadaist methodologies, this paper encourages artists to engage with generative AI in a deliberate and considered manner, reframing its outputs as tools for disruption and creative intervention.

CCS Concepts

• **Applied computing** → **Media arts**; • **Computing methodologies** → **Artificial intelligence**.

Keywords

Collage, Mixed Media, Art, Experimental Methodologies, Decontextualisation, Artificial Intelligence

ACM Reference Format:

Anika Cook. 2025. Subversive Methodologies: Dadaist Approaches to Generative AI. In *SIGGRAPH Asia 2025 Art Papers (SA Art Papers '25)*, December 15–18, 2025, Hong Kong, Hong Kong. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 6 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3757369.3767597>

1 Introduction

Generative models of artificial intelligence (AI) have transformed practices of image-making in recent years, and continue to evolve rapidly [Navajas Cawood et al. 2025]. The rise of generative AI in art has spurred debates about human-machine collaboration and distributed agency, hybridity and entanglement [Dzhimova and Tigre Moura 2024], as well as contention over the future of the creative industries.



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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-2129-8/25/12
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3757369.3767597>

In the early twentieth century the new technologies of photography and cinema destabilised and reframed art in a similar manner. Picasso reportedly said in 1910 “I’ve discovered photography. Now I can kill myself. I’ve nothing else to learn.” [Baldassari 1997, 17] Today the extraordinarily rapid development of AI-based image-making can invoke similar feelings in artists and practitioners.

The opaque ‘black box’ nature of generative models can frustrate artists who value creative control and intuitive workflows. Text-to-image models are limited in the control they offer over aspects such as composition, shape and form [Zhang et al. 2023], making it difficult for artists to translate conceptual ideas or experiment organically through layered image-building. While tools like ControlNet have improved flexibility, the fundamental disconnect between how artists work and how these engineer-designed systems operate presents both challenges and creative opportunities.

This paper asks, what methodologies can be developed to navigate this new landscape, making disruption and subversion possible? If artists seek to incorporate generative computational systems into their workflow, how can they do so while maintaining agency and creative control?

The Dada art movement (c.1915-1924) has relevant parallels with current events. Also emerging during a period of political upheaval and uncertainty, it was anti-establishment and anti-expressionist, reacting to the rapidly spreading new technologies of photography and mass media production, which had a special relationship to reality [Ades 1986, 15]. Viewing themselves as ‘engineers’, the Dadaists used the photograph against itself, slicing and reconfiguring it to radically dismember linearity and rationality. These strategies of subversion, rupture and fragmented representation can be creatively applied to the new technology of generative image-making, as can the anti-establishment ideals.

This paper examines notions of decontextualisation, chance and dissent in Dadaist photomontage, presenting it as an experimental lens through which to approach art practices utilising generative AI. It invites artists to actively and intentionally explore new technological possibilities while remaining conscious of their inbuilt structures and biases and working to subvert their proprietary formats.

Specific techniques are not addressed in detail; the paper instead seeks to present a range of methodologies for artists to consider in their own interactions with AI. The discussion is also restricted to the use of easily available generative AI models or ‘off-the-shelf’ technologies. The paper aims to provide links between two moments in time in which seismic shifts in technology, politics and culture dramatically reconfigured visual culture, and encourage contemporary artists to learn from and adapt the innovations of the past.

General information on the Dada movement is provided in the background section, with a particular focus on Hannah Höch’s innovative use of photomontage. A brief outline of generative AI models for artistic practice follows, including the opportunities and shortcomings of the technology for artists. Dadaist methodologies are examined in section 3, with analysis of Hannah Höch’s techniques providing insights that are contextualised with reference to original artworks of my own.

2 Background

2.1 Dadaism and Artistic Resistance

Though it is considered ‘un-Dadaistic’ to define Dada as a movement [Bigsby 2017, 4], critics largely agree that it emerged internationally in response to the horrors of the first World War (1914-18) and the growing saturation of a modern mass media [Hegenbart and Kölmel 2023; Hughes 1991; MoMA 2025]. Dadaists employed a range of art forms (performance, literature, painting, collage, sculpture and film) to critique societal norms, war and what they saw as the bourgeois art world.

Berlin Dadaists – primarily John Heartfield, Hannah Höch, Raoul Hausmann, Johannes Baader and George Grosz – developed and named the new technique of photomontage, an extension of collage in which photographic images and text are sliced from newspapers and magazines [Ades 1986; Hughes 1991] and pasted together in disjunctive compositions. The relatively recent inventions of photography and cinema had already prompted a reactionary move away from representational painting and into non-mimetic approaches such as Cubism and Futurism [Scheunemann 2020, 26], but artists had yet to use photographic materials and processes as primary elements in their work [Ades 1986, 12]. Dadaist photomontage, in its embrace of ‘proletariat’ materials and rejection of emotionality, expressionism and personal style [Hausmann 2012, 115], marked a new method. Scholar Dietrich Scheunemann points to a blurring of the distinction between art and technical production as the pivotal shift, questioning accepted notions of originality and uniqueness in art [Scheunemann 2020, 26].

In appropriating the power intrinsic to something materially ‘real’, the Berlin Dadaists radically redefined the concept of an art object, and exposed the underlying mechanisms of culture and mass media. This enabled them to critique society in the very medium that society used to communicate itself [Hegenbart and Kölmel 2023, 27] – a parody embedded within the dominant structure.

2.2 Generative AI in Artistic Practice

Generative AI models have revolutionised image-making in recent years, and continue to evolve rapidly [Navajas Cawood et al. 2025]. Trained on massive datasets comprising billions of images and texts scraped from the internet, deep-learning models generate realistic images from text prompts and vice versa [Somaini 2023, 75]. With a dizzying pace of development, creative practitioners in the fields of illustration, photography, animation and film must navigate a wholly new landscape and realign themselves within their industries, and visual culture more broadly. While models such as Stable Diffusion, DALL-E and Midjourney offer new creative tools, the complexity and opacity of the systems can create substantial barriers for artists who wish to use them, including limited oversight into how critical elements of the technology work and how they may be incorporated into existing artistic workflows.

Film, media and visual culture theorist Antonio Somaini cautions against an unquestioning implementation of deep-learning technologies, writing that the impact of the underlying algorithms on images must be fully understood before they become an invisible part of digital infrastructure [Somaini 2023, 76]. The initial design of early AI systems embedded assumptions and biases at the deepest levels, affecting the outputs the end user sees. For example, early



Figure 2: Hannah Höch, *Cut with the Dada Kitchen Knife through the Last Weimar Beer-Belly Cultural Epoch in Germany, 1919-20*. Collage, 114 x 90cm. © VG Bild-Kunst/Copyright Agency 2025

models predicted image quality ratings based on the most ‘liked’ photographs in their training set, as well as the programmers’ views on aesthetic value [Manovich and Arielli 2024, 9].

For artists and practitioners, issues of control, co-creation and distributed agency complicate their relationship with AI. Established artistic workflows don’t necessarily convert to AI systems. Conceptual or expressive approaches are not easily translatable into text prompts, and artists’ individual aesthetics may be inaccessible through generative AI (unless they mimic a well-known style). The opaque nature of the algorithms makes it difficult to predict how adjustments will affect outputs, disrupting the intuitive feedback loops that artists rely on. Artists may feel that AI systems are not designed for them. As conceptual artist Kevin Abosch notes, many using AI in art come from technical rather than artistic backgrounds, and prioritise novelty and ‘posturing’ over creative practice [Meier 2024]. While some artists have collaborated with engineers or built custom tools, such additions are inaccessible for most practitioners.

The proprietary nature of many generative AI systems also complexifies and obscures the ownership of resulting artworks. There is legal ambiguity surrounding intellectual property, as recent copyright infringement lawsuits demonstrate [Barnes 2025; Lee 2025].

Artworks produced may inherit these copyright issues. Furthermore, undisclosed and opaque mechanisms of content moderation, algorithmic filtering and hidden company agendas further curtail artistic autonomy and enable invisible censorship. Those who control these systems will increasingly control the affordances and limits of our participation in culture.

It is the contention of this paper that ‘off-the-shelf’ generative AI models in their current state, have significant barriers for artists that limit their usefulness. However, the paper also contends that AI can be an effective tool when used with intention, as we will see in the discussion below. Many artists of the twentieth century avoided confronting their equivalent technical revolution – photography – but the Dadaists elected to work with it in unique and innovative ways [Hemus 2009, 99], and we can follow their example. Generative AI is designed to provide a version of the world that the model thinks we want; a copy of a copy. For artists wanting to work against that bias, the Dadaists’ exploration of readymade imagery, decontextualisation and subversion of meanings are valuable methodologies.

3 Experimental Methodologies

This section outlines theoretical strategies inspired by Hannah Höch’s photomontages, to conceptually disrupt and reconfigure the outputs of generative AI. Drawing on Höch’s techniques — particularly her deliberate fragmentation, juxtaposition, and reassembly — these methodologies envision a multi-faceted approach.

3.1 Slice it

Artist Gertrud-Jula Dech outlined the political power of Höch’s photomontage technique, identifying three important elements [Hemus 2009, 104]: the cut-out imagery is taken from contemporary sources; an emphasis on the technical rather than irrational or spiritual (in opposition to Surrealist motivations and bourgeois ideals of art); and the accessibility of the technique to ‘laypeople’.

These elements reveal that the choice of technique was the political message. By cutting through readymade, whole, familiar materials and reassembling them into something dislocated, deformed and yet unified, Höch presented a vision of a familiar and yet unknowable world. The imagery that comes out of AI is similarly complete, smooth and seamless — a modern-day readymade. Choosing to slice through this imagery, and perhaps presenting it in a disjunctive, deformed way, works against the dominant use-cases of the technology and therefore their aesthetic predictability and blandness.

In my own interdisciplinary practice I have used collage techniques to disrupt the smooth completeness of AI-generated imagery. In Figure 3, AI was used to generate videos of the two characters moving around. I then combined the footage together and divided it into strips, using this juxtaposition to disrupt the continuous picture plane. A sequence of PNGs was created, printed and then physically cut to create ‘real’ strips. This was then animated back together to form the final piece. It is a relatively simple approach but sits within the space of being familiar and yet ambiguous, with the method of creation remaining uncertain.



Figure 3: Anika Cook, *Strips*, 2025. Animated collage still, dimensions variable.

3.2 Situating in Time

Höch and the Berlin Dadaists sourced their readymade imagery from daily magazines, advertisements and newspapers, generally restricting themselves to the leading articles [Hemus 2009, 97]; [Bergius 1996, 108], which ensured that the cut imagery would be familiar to viewers. This ‘already seen’ element [Hemus 2009, 104] contributed to the subverted impact of the decontextualised, disjunctive arrangement, and also situated Höch’s pieces in a very specific time and place.

Generative AI outputs tend to have a non-specific nature to them – they exhibit familiarity without being situated within time. Markers of ‘real’ materials are suggested to create socially situated artworks and disrupt that drifting timelessness. In my ongoing *Remove* series I use AI to remove people from old film stills, then delete the background so that the removed sections are the only remnant of the image. I often then layer a different film still underneath, in which any people have also been removed (see Figure 4). The result is an image that features no pixels from the original photo, but retains something of its aura and physicality, which enables it to be temporally situated. Specificity and materiality, and a refusal to let AI update them, can be powerful tools to question accepted aesthetics and representations of reality. Today we often ask ourselves ‘is it real?’ with no real way to answer the question. AI can exist in a contextless void – retaining or creating context through materials can bring back the agency and control that artists need, and can enable compelling messaging.

Interestingly, the visual glitches of AI-generated imagery function to situate artefacts within their time. These ‘mistakes’ will disappear as models improve, so emphasising glitches, hallucinations, deformed fingers, extra limbs and uncanny movements can provide a specific temporal element. French-Canadian artist Gregory Chatonsky’s *Double Glove V* series playfully explores this in images of deformed and unrealistic gloves, to match AI’s deformed and unrealistic hands [Chatonsky 2023].

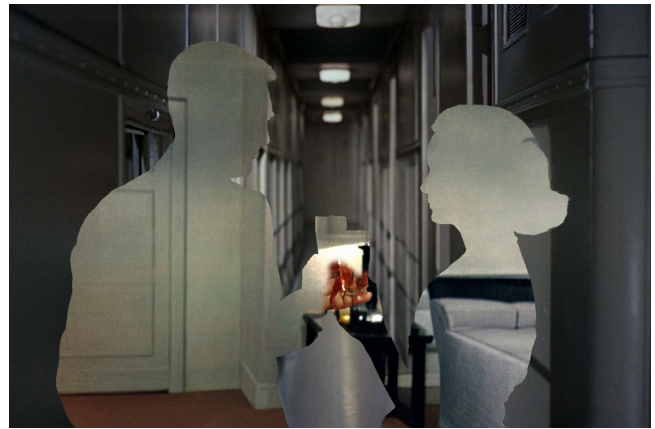


Figure 4: Anika Cook, *Remove* (series), 2025. Digital collage, dimensions variable.

3.3 Avoiding the Feedback Loop

Generative AI tools tend to have a ‘house style’ [Manovich and Arielli 2024, 83] and generate imagery that is more stereotyped than the user may intend [Manovich and Arielli 2024, 89]. As more and more generated imagery is uploaded to the internet and becomes part of new datasets, it is conceivable that this feedback loop will worsen [Somai 2023, 105]. Artists like Jake Elwes have tackled the issue in projects such as *Zizi - Queering the Dataset*, which responds to the lack of diversity in AI datasets by retraining them with images of drag and gender fluid faces [Elwes 2019], but the fact remains that it can be difficult to achieve non-stereotypical results. Careful consideration of prompt inputs and integrating paradoxical, disjunctive, or non-sequitur phrases, may evoke a sense of visual and conceptual dissonance akin to the fragmentation evident in Höch’s work. Removing AI outputs from their models and applying other techniques, is also an effective, hybrid approach.

Höch delegated a level of control to the commercial mass media, which created the imagery and text she used in her photomontages. Once those fragments had been appropriated however, she exerted control over every aspect of the work. Höch describes the process as a measured construction, worked through systematically: “From that point on... chance can hardly intervene: not in the building of form, and not in the content,” [Hemus 2009, 99].

Hybrid techniques and mediums can help to avoid the feedback loop. In my own digital work I take AI outputs and insert them into pre-existing contemporary collage workflows. In *Pearls* (Figure 5) I had generated various images of classic film actresses for a previous project which didn’t work out. I merged the faces together and created extra artefacts to make it seem as though the figures were both fused together, and breaking apart. I used AI to add rippling water, and then made further adjustments to composition, lighting and colour in Photoshop. This is quite close to my usual workflow when making a digital image, and allowed me full control over the final piece. It may seem obvious, but a valid use case for AI is to use it to create any visual elements that are needed, and nothing further.



Figure 5: Anika Cook, *Pearls*, 2025. Digital image, dimensions variable.

3.4 The Craft

Looking at Höch's creative approach, we see that she employed painstaking attention to detail, systematically working through collected imagery and building the form of the photomontage in a measured process, a piece of labour [Hemus 2009, 99]. Generative AI is sometimes presented as a quick fix – as photography would have been in Höch's day – an alternative to labour-intensive forms of artistic creation. In this environment, deliberateness and intentionality become not merely aesthetic choices, but a form of resistance and a way of returning fundamental decision-making to the artist. Time-consuming manual processes and conscious, deliberate experimentation creates space for reflection, evaluation and discovery. Ideas can be developed intuitively in response to material properties, leading to tactile satisfaction and an accumulation of skills. This joy, inherent in making, raises questions about what might be lost in a transition away from creative labour.

4 Conclusion

This paper has explored the conceptual and practical resonances between early twentieth-century Dadaist photomontage and contemporary generative AI practices. By dissecting the methodologies of decontextualisation, disjunction, and removal, it has argued for an intentional and experimental approach to AI art-making that does not simply accept algorithmic outputs but actively interrogates their use. The lessons drawn from Höch's methodologies suggest that our relationship with AI in creative practice need not be one of unthinking adoption or complete renunciation, but rather strategic integration that preserves the essential qualities of human creative engagement.

The methodological ideas presented above suggest that by adopting strategies of decontextualisation and subversion, artists can recover a measure of agency in a field increasingly dominated by technological determinism. In their engagement, artists have the opportunity to critique and reshape the narrative of digital creation, pushing the boundaries of what is aesthetically conceivable. As Höch wrote in 1934 about photography, AI represents a "new magical territory" and we must be "open to the beauties of fortuity" [Höch 2012].

This open approach necessitates an appropriately collaborative response from technology firms that build AI models, with a commitment to preserving and enhancing, not displacing, the unique role of human creativity in this new digital landscape. Only through such mutual commitment can we ensure that AI becomes a tool for expanding, rather than constraining, creative practice and expression.

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